Ashoka in Ancient India is a historical study of the life and times of the emperor through his epigraphs, through the archaeology and traditions in and around the places where these were put up, and through an imaginative construction of how people in ancient India are likely to have understood these messages. The historical narrative in this book is not organized around the themes that many books on Ashoka are: the emperor's early life and later history, his empire and administration, the social and economic conditions of Mauryan India, Ashoka's policy of dhamma and his proclivity for constructing monuments, the emperor's place in the larger scheme of ancient India. Instead, mine is a narrative account of Ashoka in which a clear path that follows the trajectory of his life cuts through the jungle of legends and traditions, the epigraphs and monuments, and the archaeological facts and detail that surround him. Its narrative form will, I hope, also make it attractive to readers who enjoy digs into the past.[58]

As I began writing this book I found myself facing two dilemmas. First, notwithstanding the many accounts of Ashoka's life, I realized that the crafting of such a history is limited by the restrictions of sources, for crucial phases in the individual life which forms the subject of the narrative do not figure in accounts contemporary with him. The historical life of Ashoka only began when he started speaking through his epigraphs, a little after *c.* 260 BCE, this being much after he captured the throne at Pataliputra. This meant that to reconstruct his early life as a prince a different narrative strategy was required. What I therefore chose to do was use the archaeological resonances of ancient life that can be mined out of the many landscapes in India associated with Ashoka's princely years. This is one of the biggest problems with his early life: context and conjecture have to serve as compensatory mechanisms. To put it another way, in order to compensate the lack of textual detail I have used archaeology extensively to evoke the times in which Ashoka lived.